SpeechGeek



Season Ten: Winter 2013

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Looking back, 2012 has been an action-packed year. *The Avengers* and *The Dark Knight* muscled their way into theaters and rescued lagging box office sales. Strength and agility also helped U.S. Olympians like Gabby Douglas bring home the gold. And chances are—if you're reading this—the Mayan calendar is being filed away with Y2K in the "Unnecessary End-of-the-Year Worries" box.

While everyone is trying to remember to write the right year, you've got plenty of other things keeping you busy. We're in the full swing of tournament season with district, state, and even national tournaments on the horizon. Your brain is chock full of memorized pieces, tournament planning to-do lists, and polishing pieces after reading ballots. The last thing you need to remember is to go out searching for new literature. That's why we went ahead and published five new pieces in addition to this letter. What a bargain!

Here's hoping that 2013 brings you good fortune, great ballots, and unforgettable performances!

Corey Alderdice
Publisher



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Content

by Wes Tantz

(*While smoking cigarette, Marion should be making subtle touches to her stomach because she is with child—but it shouldn't be obvious.)*

MARION. (*reading from book*) "Poets are always taking the weather so seriously. They are always sticking their emotions in things that have no feelings."

When I first started writing, I used to hail these gaudy beings as proof for why I was the way I was or why I did the things I did. After months of reading, re-reading, and a descent into nihilism, I just realized I was a woman who was too busy rotating on my axis to focus on the planets and shooting stars around me.

(*reading from book)* "All cowardice comes from not loving or not loving well."

Then again, maybe that's what it is. All of these people are too much on their axis, too. Or too busy sucking the life out of anything that remained nameless. You know, I never understood why love was such a holy topic. It's not all that, let me tell you. Let me tell you a story.

I knew a girl once who fell so in love with a boy. She fell and fell and fell and fell so far past the Earth that she spiraled out into the universe. She was carried by all these feelings that seemed warm and comforting, but once thrown into space, they were nothing. She floated with the dust and fell and fell and came to a black hole. There, she was sucked inside, and what did she find? Well, a party! There was booze, there was coke, there were people, and she danced until the stars shook and fell to her feet. There was John Lennon, Albert Einstein, and Ernest Hemingway. And you'll never believe who was hosting the party. Jesus H. Christ himself! Dressed in a pink suit, all Gatsby-like. So cool and so clique, waiting on his Daisy to float on by…(*laughs*). Hmm. You know that's why people never return from black holes. It's one endless party. I mean who'd want to? She sent me a postcard once. It was real nice. Jesus is a handsome looking fellow let me tell you. (*She laughs and continues to smoke.*)

I know this other story. Oh, but you don't want to hear more, do you? Oh, well… If you insist. See, once there was this boy—a very pretty boy. A good friend of mine knew him. Now, I didn't know him personally, but my good friend told me he fell in love. How surprising, right? Said he fell so in love that the earth knew it and the ground knew it and the trees knew it and the ocean knew it. So the earth told the trees to separate the earth, and the ground split beneath his little toes, and he fell into the ocean. He swam and swam to find the little mermaid's hoarding spot just to find his lover a ring. (*laughs*) You didn't seem to like that one very much. You know, everyone is a critic now a day. You should try being a writer. It isn't as glamorous as it looks. Although I do a great job at making it flawless, huh?

I don't mean to be a critic. Days like these just happen to mangle and deform me. How about one last story? The story of the girl who wanted to be God. Maybe you've heard Sylvia Plath's version, but mine's better. I promise. See, there was a girl who wanted to be God. Instead of floating in the dust of stars or swimming to please, she wanted to be a supernova—to combust into a brilliant light and then nothing. Nothing. And it worked. All of the boys and all of the girls, they fell for the trick. The mystery and allure and never experiencing anything because she burst before their eyes.

I remember seeing her. In the coffeehouse all of us writers went to, to wear our best outfit of despair and attract a cure…or a catalyst…to teach us how to really burn. That night, she was the most inappropriately dressed out of everyone. I kid you not, this girl was practically emotionally naked sitting in the coffeehouse reading her book on neurology or physiology or some "ology," and she just looked like bliss. Not *in* bliss, but she was the goddess of it. I remember staring and wanting nothing more than to have her—to have another moon to pull into my gravity and rotate about my self-centeredness. But that's when mermaid boy found his way out of the ocean; he wound up in the sewer and crawled from the toilet dripping wet footprints to my table to remind me I was still his. He stands in front of me, and I stare at the floor to catch her shadow. His mouth is moving and mine is following, too, but the words don't process, and it's just my eyes. From the girl to him to her hips to his face to her eyes to his mouth from her eyelashes that I swear were cyclones pulling me into

his arms—reaching into his pocket to her fingertips flipping a page to him. He pulls out a velvet box, and she looks up. I catch her eye from his sideline, and his hands are opening the box, and she stares, and my eyes dart to seeing mouth and tongue say:

(*imitating her*) "Yes."

Yes. Yes… yes… yes. (*holding stomach*). I tried to justify the choices I'd made by saying that I'd fix it tomorrow. I tried to justify *that* day by saying that *yesterday* just wasn't the day. To be quite honest, I have no excuse for this…not right now. See, it is the presence of love that makes cowards. The presence of truth that can make even the girl who wanted to be God—the girl who stayed in the black hole party—to become his little daisy. (*touching her stomach*) Little daisy that bloomed little lilacs from her gardens. If man came from man and woman came from rib—from bone—then does that mean, once broken, we can only become stronger, once healed, and put in place by a cast? Instead, is it like a tree that grows crooked and somehow manages to crawl towards light despite the odds? I am not—despite the odds. I do not believe I am woman. I am not bone. I cannot heal. Because when I stare at myself, all I can see is the outside of me saying yes. Saying yes and the face of naked "ology" staring at me. Because somewhere in the darkest corner of my mind, I convinced myself that she knew.

The scene morphs and morphs into my head, and all I can do is go back. Because if I saw myself then, I could do it again, right? I'd make my lips and my mouth move and say no and say no. No, I didn't want the ring. And, no, I didn't want his hands. And, no, I didn't want his fish breath or the pride taken from a man who swam the seven seas. And, no, I didn't want mediocrity. And, no, I didn't want this. I didn't want him for the fruit and flower of our lie. And, no, I don't want this. I don't want this. I don't want this (*hits stomach*).

(*reads from book)* "Poets are always taking things so personally." Just a nicer way of saying we were too sensitive to deal with things the correct way. Because somewhere we learned that our emotions could be catered to. Whether from paper and pen or drugs…or man.

I remember my mother used to tell me "*Los hombres tenien sue sufrir. Si no, es la mujer sue hacen sufrir.*" Man must suffer. If not, then he will place the burden on woman to suffer.

And yet I think we both do the combined job well.

All I wanted was to be God—to be that flash of light, eternity, and clarity. Then nothing. The ultimate stillness. The ultimate stillness.